

WILLIS'S
CURRENT NOTES:

A SERIES OF ARTICLES

ON

Antiquities, Biography, Heraldry, History, Language,
Literature, Topography, Curious Customs, &c.

SELECTED FROM

ORIGINAL LETTERS AND DOCUMENTS

ADDRESSED DURING THE YEAR

1852,

TO THE PUBLISHER,

G. WILLIS,

GREAT PIAZZA, COVENT GARDEN, LONDON.

MDCCLIII.

Vol. XV.
March

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CURRENT NOTES, NO. 15, MARCH 1852 ***

WILLIS'S CURRENT NOTES FOR THE MONTH.

No. XV.]

"I will make a prief of it in my Note-Book."—
SHAKSPERE. [MARCH, 1852.

NOTICE TO SUBSCRIBERS

TO THE "PRICE CURRENT OF LITERATURE."

G. WILLIS gratefully acknowledges the various interesting documents and letters he has received. He is anxious that it should be perfectly understood that he is not the author of any statement, representation, or opinion, that may appear in his "Current Notes," which are merely selections from communications made to him in the course of his business, and which appear to him to merit attention. Every statement therefore is open to correction or discussion, and the writers of the several paragraphs should be considered as alone responsible for their assertions. Although many notes have hitherto appeared anonymously, or with initial letters, yet wherever a serious contradiction is involved, G. Willis trusts that his Correspondents will feel the necessity of allowing him to make use of their names when properly required.

MEDIAEVAL MUMMIES.

British Museum, Jan. 1852.

SIR,—The late discovery of the remains of a human body in a complete state of preservation, in St. Stephen's Chapel, has induced me to send you a brief notice of several similar occurrences recorded by our early chroniclers and historians. Bede relates that eleven years after the death of St. Cuthbert, bishop of Lindisfarne, the monks took up his body, expecting to see it reduced to ashes, but found, "all the body whole, as if it had been alive, and the joints pliable more like one asleep than a dead person; besides all the vestments the body had on were wonderful for their freshness and glossness." We learn from William of Malmesbury that the body was again found incorrupt 415 years afterwards at Durham, and publicly shewn. Lingard gives an interesting account of the event, taken "from a memoir written at the time by an eye-witness," in all probability Simeon, the Durham historian. From this narrative it appears that when the monks removed the masonry of the tomb, "they beheld a large and ponderous chest, which had been entirely covered with leather, and strongly secured with nails and plates of iron. To separate the top from the sides required their utmost exertion, and within it they discovered a second chest, of dimensions more proportionate to the human body. It was of black oak, carved with figures of animals and flowers, and wrapped in a coarse linen cloth, which had previously been dipped in melted wax, to exclude the air and damp." By the direction of Turgot, the prior, "they conveyed the smaller chest from behind the altar to a more convenient place, in the middle of the choir, unrolled the cloth, and with trembling hands forced open the lid. Instead of the remains of the Saint, they found a copy of the Gospels lying on a second lid, which had not been fastened with nails, but rested on three transverse bars of wood. By the help of two iron rings, fixed at the extremities, it was easily removed, and disclosed the body apparently entire, lying on its right side, on a pallet of silk. At the sight they gazed on each other in silent astonishment, and then retiring a few paces, fell prostrate on the floor, and repeated, in a low tone, the seven penitential psalms. After this preparation, they approached the coffin, and three of them, by order of

the prior, placing their hands under the head, the feet, and the middle of the body, raised it up, and laid it on a carpet spread on the floor. It was found to have been wrapped in a cerecloth of linen. Over this appeared the usual episcopal vestments, the amice, alb, stole, fanon tunic and dalmatic;—the chasuble alone was wanting, which had been removed at the former translation in 689. On the forehead lay a thin plate of gold, or metal gilt, thickly encrusted with small stones; and a mitre covered the head, round which had been wound a napkin of purple colour. A cerecloth of the finest linen adhered so closely to the face, that no part of it could be loosened, but between the neck and the shoulders the skin was exposed to the sight and touch. The arms could be moved with ease; the hands were joined over the lower part of the chest, and the fingers, which were still flexible, pointed upwards. With the body were found a chalice, patine, a portable altar, a burse to hold the linen for the altar, and an ivory comb, with scissors of silver." When the shrine of St. Cuthbert was plundered and demolished by order of that sacrilegious scoundrel King Harry the Eighth, the body was still found entire, as Harpsfield testifies.

Audry, a daughter of Annas, King of the East Angles, and abbess of Ely Monastery, died A.D. 679, and was buried in a wooden coffin. Sixteen years afterwards her sister caused her body to be exhumed. It was found "free from corruption, and all the linen cloths in which the body had been wrapped appeared entire, and as fresh as if they had been that very day wrapped about her limbs." Such are the words of the physician who attended her in her last illness, and who saw the occurrence. (Bede, B. 4. c. 19).

Wereburge, a daughter of Wulfere, king of Mercia, died about the close of the seventh century. Her body, according to her own desire, was interred at Hanbury. Nine years afterwards, in 708, it was taken up in presence of King Cöelred, his Council, and many bishops, and being found entire and incorrupt, was laid in a costly shrine. In 875 her body was still entire; when, for fear of the Danish pirates, it was removed to Chester, and soon after its translation, fell into decay.

St. Elphege, Archbishop of Canterbury, was barbarously murdered by the Danes in 1012, and buried in St. Paul's Cathedral. Twelve years after his martyrdom, his body was found entire, and solemnly translated to

Canterbury. The King and Queen, and an incredible multitude of persons following the procession from London. A long narrative of the event is amongst the Harleian MSS.

When King Edmund was cruelly slain by the Danes in 870, his head was carried by the infidels into a wood, and thrown into a brake of bushes; but being afterwards discovered, it was deposited with the royal remains at Hoxon, which were soon afterwards conveyed to Bury St. Edmunds, and there honourably interred. Fifty-seven years rolled on, when his body was taken up by order of the good Bishop of London; on which occasion, says the author of *Britannia Sancta*, "his body, to the admiration of all, was not only found entire, and without any blemish of corruption, much more like to one lying in a sweet sleep than one dead; but also his wounds were found all closed up, and his head united to the rest of his body, only a slender mark remaining like a red thread around the neck, testifying their former separation."

Yours, truly,
A BOOKWORM.

ARMS OF THE ISLE OF MAN.

Southwick, near Oundle,
Feb. 27th, 1852.

SIR,—The accompanying woodcut, taken from Gesenii Monumenta Phœnicia, Tab. 23, fig. 59, has induced me to send you a description of the remaining figures of the precious fragment, and the history written underneath them.

The upper part of the stone contained, *probably*, the infant Jesus and his mother Mary. Immediately beneath her feet is the figure here described; and below it is an ox at his manger; and underneath the feet of the ox, an ancient writing, of which the following is the meaning.



"The illuminated star (spica Virginis) of Virgo led the Magi slowly to the inn filled within, and in the court-yard, with crowds of people. Arriving at the mean cattle-stable, the Magi were." The names of the *three* chiefs of the Magi in the place of the erasures? From a Mukatteb inscription I get the name of one of them, viz. "Nathan Hafi, the Grandfather."

Now what can the three legs, with the *man's* head in the middle denote, but the three *chiefs* of the Magi? And how is it that the people of Mona adopted it as *their* peculiar coat of arms, if *a portion* of that sect did not establish themselves, after the nativity, in the isle of Mona? The passage in Matt. ii. 12, does not militate against the idea.

Let us now take that most valuable auxiliary, Etymology, in order that we may further elucidate the subject.

Mannin, the Isle of Man, Mana, or Mona, may be thus divided, Man-n-in. Persian, *māna*, a sect of the Magi. Sanscrit, *māna*, to investigate, seek or desire knowledge, to give knowledge, to respect, *revere*, *worship*. A. Saxon *mont-ige*, *Mona* insula; *monige*, *monitiæ*; *monigean*, *monere*, to teach, instruct, &c. Gaelic, *man-ach*, a monk.

And lastly, let us not despise tradition, however absurd it may at first sight appear.

Among a few legends, I have been told one, probably imperfectly, by a lady; viz. "A man was thrown from the top of a mountain in Mona; and was afterwards, sometimes seen as a sheep in the plain below, sometimes as a goat." Will any person of *Mannin veg veen* do me the favour of giving the *complete* legend; with any other legend respecting the peopling of their island? It may throw more light on the *peculiar* occupation of the Magi.

Your's truly,
T. R. BROWN.

G. W. fears, with regret, that the "PUNCH" Artist, to whom his learned Correspondent's sketch was forwarded to copy, has been more humourous than correct in its transfer.

DANIEL O'ROURKE.

There is a sort of mystery attached to this legend or story, as to the authorship of it, that requires some clearing up.

The first time I read it was in T. C. Croker's "Fairy Legends," which appeared in 1825, 3 vols. small 8vo.; but what the editor or writer calls a compressed edition, forms a volume of "Murray's Family Library," and was published in 1834. At page 134 of this latter edition the story commences, as if narrated by Daniel himself, and the writer says, "I knew the man well,—an old man was he at the time *he told me the story*, and it was on the 25th of June, 1813, that *I heard it from his own lips*."

All this seems very circumstantial, but it is somewhat singular that this same story, with very slight variation, is to be found in the 18th volume of Dr. Anderson's "Bee," for January, 1794, p. 338, the party communicating it, saying, "The inclosed is genuine, and I honour the *lady* who had the merit of putting it in writing."

There is also some account of its previous publication, communicated in the 34th volume of the "Dublin University Magazine," p. 202, but not having the volume at hand, I do not recollect the particulars, my chief object being to refer to Prior's "Memoir of the Life of Burke," third edition, 1839, at p. 100 of which we are distinctly told that Mr. Doyle, a surgeon, of Dublin, was the *author* of Daniel O'Rourke's Dream.

Now it is right that the real author should not be deprived of the merit of a story, which has even been translated into French, and published in the "Magasin Pittoresque" for 1843, with two humorous wood cuts.

A.

Oak House.

TRADESMEN'S TOKENS.

Dublin, March 5th, 1852.

SIR,—I was much pleased with the observations which appeared in the last number of your Current Notes, (p. 11) by your intelligent Correspondent, Mr. Boyne of Leeds, respecting the tokens issued by tradesmen in the seventeenth century. But as he states that the only instance with which he is acquainted of one bearing the Arms of the Commonwealth is that which you have engraved to illustrate his paper, it is evident that Mr. Boyne cannot have seen Dr. Aquilla Smith's Catalogue of the Tradesmen's Tokens current in Ireland between the years 1637 and 1679 which was printed in 1849 in the 2nd part of the 4th volume (8vo.) of the Transactions of the Royal Irish Academy, for on the very same page in which John Whittle's issue is enumerated, a token for the County of Kerry issued by T. S. is mentioned as bearing "*The Commonwealth Arms*." From my own collection I can give another instance, inscribed on both sides A. CORKE. FARTHING.

The list of Irish Tokens formed by Lindsay in 1839 amounts to only 195; while that published ten years afterwards by Dr. Smith extends to 552;—and I would respectfully call Mr. Boyne's attention to it.

Your very humble servant,

K. L.

Southwick, near Oundle,
Feb. 27th, 1852.

SIR,—Finding by Mr. Boyne's communication in your Current Notes, that Tradesmen's Tokens are worth collecting, I beg to send for your acceptance five dug up in my own gardens. You may make what use you please of them.

Yours truly,

T. R. BROWN.

JOHN. EATON. OUNDLE (*dug up in my garden at Southwick by myself.*)

JAMES MEAD, 1667 (an Angel) IN TENTARDEN. HIS HALFPENY.

JOHN COVITER (Coat of Arms) GROCER. IN. WYE, 1662,

And two German Counters.

Dug up in my garden at Woodchurch, near Tenterden, Kent, by myself.

G. W. sincerely thanks his Correspondent, and with his permission will consider these tokens at Mr. Boyne's service should he wish for them.

SIR,—Mr. William Boyne, in your "Current Notes" for February, asks any of your readers to inform him if there were any Tradesmen's Tokens of Scotland issued during the seventeenth century. I find in a small collection of Tokens I possess, an Edinburgh and Glasgow halfpenny, dates 1791 and 1793, proving there were some during the eighteenth century, though I have never met with any of an earlier date.

Yours, &c.

M. A. M.

March 12, 1852.

THE HISTORIC SOCIETY OF LANCASHIRE AND CHESHIRE.—T. M. considers the Rev. Dr. Hume's "attack" upon him ("Current Notes," for February, p. 10) to be "most unfair and uncalled for." He, however, admits the accuracy of Dr. Hume's statement, and withdraws his charge of the unacknowledged appropriation of his communication, although he questions the Rev. Gentleman's taste or temper in accusing him of want of patience or civility.

"My copy," writes T. M. "does not contain the pages which were forwarded to you by Dr. Hume, and you have sent on to me. How, therefore, could I overlook pages which do not exist in my copy? Now, suppose no such pipe ever existed, but in the fumes of my brain (for I sometimes have strange fancies), and that I, in a hoaxing humour, transferred it to paper, and transmitted it to you. I say, again, suppose that no such inn ever existed at Fulham as the Golden Lion—would not I have an everlasting laugh at the learned Doctor Hume, and the Historic Society of Lancashire and Cheshire, and "Willis's Current Notes?" And would it not make as good a story as Bishop Heber's, or James Smith's hoaxes upon the venerable 'Gentleman's Magazine,' or Dr. Maginn's Correspondence with the trusty 'Times;' or Hook's political information to the 'Morning Post;' or the recent Roman Bridge affair, and Lord Goring's cobbler's bill, about his corns, in the York papers? Look to this, Mr. Willis; and don't encourage men to try and defend themselves at the expense of your Correspondent."

T. M.

TOBACCO.—The charge made against the Historical Society of Lancashire and Cheshire, by your correspondent T. M. in your "Current Notes" for January (p. 5), induced me to refer to the former numbers, of which, as I do not possess a complete set, I will thank you to forward me a copy of the Collected Edition you have announced. But, as by looking over the numbers which I have, I find that T. M. (see "Current Notes" for Feb. 1851, p. 13), is curious upon the subject of smoking and tobacco, I send you the following extract from an old miscellaneous manuscript book which came into my possession a few years since at Gloucester, and has the dates 1699 and 1703, with the names Bubb or Butt and Richard Smith in it—but part of which is written in a much earlier hand.

*"I was tempted to smoke no tobac
And to smoke.
"When the (HOLY) Angel (SPIRIT) torn'd I
Discorst on to the other
I told him that I*

*Did think not to smoke no more
Tobacko nor drink no more Alle
And I have. I hope the Lord
Will forgive me, as he told the
Spirit blind me, and ever since
I have been tempted to smoke and
Not to smok. The Angel Spirit
Is you when I do smok no tobac
But when I do he comes to me
Again and I am tempted to smok."*

What an extraordinary record is this of a mental struggle to overcome the cravings for Tobacco and Ale.

S. T.

Chester, February 4th.

WHAT HAS BEEN THE HIGHEST PRICE EVER PAID FOR A VOLUME?—In the course of my reading lately on Bibliography, I observe that at the sale of the Duke of Roxburgh's Library in May, 1812, the first edition of the Decamerone of Boccaccio produced the enormous sum of £2260. In the Catalogue the work is entitled—

"Boccaccio il Decamerone. Fol. M. G. Ediz. Prim. Venet. Valdarfer, 1471."

It was bought by the Duke of Marlborough, and again sold by public auction from his Library, by Mr. Evans, Pall Mall, in June, 1819, for the large price of £918. 15s. In that Catalogue it is entitled—

"Boccaccio il Decamerone, (Venezia), per Christoful Valdarfer di Ratispona, MCCCCLXXI."

At this time it was purchased by Mr. Longman, apparently for Lord Spencer, in whose library it is said at present to be. A note to the above

Catalogue mentions that, "notwithstanding the publicity of the extraordinary sum which this book produced at the Roxburgh Sale, all researches throughout Europe to procure another copy have proved entirely fruitless. This volume still continues to be the only known perfect copy of this edition, and is, in all probability, the only copy which will ever be offered for public sale. Its unparalleled rarity, however, is not its only recommendation, as it contains many important readings which have not been followed in any subsequent edition."

If any of your learned correspondents could give us additional information as to this rare and apparently valuable volume, it would be doubtless interesting to Bibliographers. Has any volume ever brought a higher price, or any work even in a series of volumes?

It is most probable that the other copies of this Edition have fallen under the ban of the Pope.

W. B. M.

JAMES SMITH. The mention of this gentleman by your Correspondent J. in your "Current Notes" for January (p. 7), reminds me that no author in the English language ever received so high a remuneration "per line" for his verses as James Smith. Longman's famous payment to Moore of a guinea a line for "Lalla Rookh" is as nothing to it, for Mr. Strachan, the King's printer, was so pleased with an epigram by Smith of eight lines, that he actually, in a codicil to his will bequeathed him £3000, or £375 per line.

R. S.

O. SMITH! The name of the "far famed Ruffian of the Adelphi," as your Correspondent, Mr. John Smith, in your Current Notes for January last, p. 7, is pleased to style a gentleman of quiet habits and literary tastes, whose real Christian names, are Richard John—the O being merely his theatrical

soubriquet, possesses in his Album among many other interesting records the following witty testimonial from the late Mr. Mathews:

"I am happy to have it in my power to express my perfect belief that Mr. O. Smith is a most respectable character in private life, though a Great Ruffian on the Stage."

C. MATHEWS.

*"Theatre Royal,
English Opera House,
August 21st, 1827."*

I was so much pleased with this impromptu by Mathews, that I asked Mr. Smith's permission to copy it, and I have no hesitation in sending you my transcript to make what use of it you like.

A. B. C.

CAMPANALOGIA.

SIR,—I thank you for amending the errors and omissions about the *Bawdrick*, though at the cost of publishing to all the world that "my writing is indistinct."

I also thank your Strood Correspondent for his extract from an old Churchwarden's book, bearing on the item *Baldrick*.

I would request the favour of any of your readers who have access to old parish accounts, to publish, through the medium of your "Current Notes," (pace tuâ) any entry relating to that *item*, or to the "*Wheles of ye Belles*."

It is a desideratum in Campanalogical history, *when* and by *whom* the ingenious and beautiful Bell-wheel now in use was first introduced. In some retired villages, and indeed very generally in Dorsetshire, the *half wheel* may still be found. Bells so hung and rung, are said to be with a "*Dead Rope*." The Bell can only be "*set*" one way, and changes could not be rung on the system now practised, viz. changing the position of each bell at every half pull.

The mention of this original sort of wheel may induce some of your readers to wend their way into the Bell-chambers in their neighbourhood, and, regardless of the filthy state in which most will be found when they get there, they will, perhaps, crawl under the bells (minding their heads), and hunt out and report if they meet with any clappers hung with Bawdricks and Busk Boards, obliging many others besides your scribbler.

H. T. E.

Feb. 26, 1852.

THE UNION JACK.

SIR,—I have met in some collection of National papers with an account of the formation of our British Union Jack; but the book has altogether escaped my memory. Can you or your readers kindly name it, to yours, &c.

H. M.

London, Feb. 17, 1852.

PILLAR PRINT OF OLIVER CROMWELL.

SIR,—All I can tell your correspondent, "A Young Print and Portrait Collector," in reply to his inquiry, p. 7, in your "Current Notes" for January, is, that I hope I may congratulate him on the possession of a very valuable and historically interesting engraving.

Horace Walpole mentions it as in "Dugdale's Origines Juridiciales," and describes it as "a large emblematic sheet print of Oliver Cromwell, whole-length, in armour, with variety of devices and mottoes."—*Proof*.

Granger describes it thus: "Oliver Cromwell standing with a book in his hand betwixt two pillars; various emblems. Faithorne, sc. sh." And Granger adds: "I do not remember to have seen more than two proofs of this fine print. Mr. Walpole had one, and Mr. Gulston another. Mr. Bull has the original drawing. The face was altered to that of King William."

A manuscript note upon my interleaved copy of Granger, which you may remember I purchased of you, states that, "*Caulfield had not less than ten or twelve of this print, but in consequence of the size they were mostly damaged: Coram had a tolerable good one which he sold to Mr. Townley for thirty guineas.*" Caulfield, who was a well known print dealer, says in his "Calcuttographiana," (1814), "The late Mr. Bull shewed me Faithorne's original drawing, from which he engraved the print, and a most brilliant proof impression; from him I also learnt the face was afterwards altered to that of William III., in which state, however, I never saw it." He describes the print as "Oliver Cromwell standing between two pillars, inscribed the 'EMBLEM OF ENGLAND'S DISTRACTIONS AS ALSO HER ATTAINED AND FURTHER HAPPINESS:' *large sheet*;" and values the print at no less a sum than £36. This was all very well for a dealer's valuation; however, if your correspondent will refer to the records of the Strawberry Hill Sale, he will find in the Sixth Day's Sale of the Prints, (18th June, 1842), that mentioned by Granger, Lot. "761. Oliver Cromwell, whole-length, in armour, standing between two columns, and otherwise surrounded by a variety of allegories and emblematic devices, entitled, THE EMBLEME OF ENGLAND'S DISTRACTIONS, AS

ALSO OF HER ATTAINED AND FURTHER EXPECTED FREEDOME AND HAPPINESS: sheet, *extra rare*;" which Mr. Evans, (a dealer also), then secured for £7 15s. The discrepancies between the two Inscriptions appear to me to be worthy of remark, and if both have been correctly copied, with what has been stated respecting the appropriation of the head to William III., would shew that the plate had been altered more than once. The original plate is supposed to have been engraved by Faithorne, while a prisoner in London for his adherence to the cause of Charles I., and to have been so favourably received by the Parliamentary party, as to have occasioned his liberation; and the alteration of the head is attributed to his son, William Faithorne, who was an engraver also.

A COLLECTOR.

Mr. Willis.

ROMAN REMAINS AT ASHTEAD, SURREY.

A Subscriber writes—"I am not aware that this locality has received from Mr. Roach Smith, the eminent Antiquary—in fact our best authority upon Roman remains—that attention which I am convinced it deserves. The arch of a small window on the North side of Ashtead Church is turned with Roman tiles, and a variety of interesting fragments have been found in the vicinity—particularly portions of a Hypocaust, of one of which you have a representation half the size of the original—the subject is evidently a wolf attacking a stag."



F. K.

THE DEVONSHIRE COLLECTION.

—— Castle,
16th January, 1852.

SIR,—I rather think the Devonshire Collection is either at the Duke's residence at Chiswick or Chatsworth. But your correspondent, (who signs himself "A Young Numismatist," p. 95, of your "Current Notes" for December), would be best answered if inquiry were made at the fountain-head; for a more amiable or kinder-hearted nobleman does not exist, than his Grace the Duke of Devonshire. Is your correspondent quite sure, however, that the Collection is Numismatic? I know the Duke of Devonshire has an invaluable Collection of Antique Gems, both Cameo and Intaglio.

Your obedient Servant,

B.

Mr. Willis.

ROWLAND HILL AND THE PENNY POSTAGE.

Bristol, 5, Lodge Street,
February 26th, 1852.

SIR,—Seeing that the inquiry made by your Correspondent, I. E., and which appeared in your "Current Notes" for January last, p. 6, in a paragraph entitled, "Rowland Hill and the Penny Postage," has not been answered in the "Current Notes," for this month, I will inform you that the traveller mentioned in that paragraph was not *Rowland Hill*, but *Coleridge*. The fact was mentioned by Mr. Commissioner Hill (brother to Rowland Hill), in the last of two lectures, which he gave at the Bristol Philosophical Institution, on the evening of the 29th ultimo, "on Postal Arrangements," which I attended. An extract of the Lecture is to be found in the Bristol newspapers, and especially in the Times and Gazette, from which I copy the portion which has reference to the "Inquiry:"

"Many instances were related of the uselessness of the Post-office of those days to the poor; and the Lecturer took occasion to remark how often we were wrong and selfish in measuring any expense by our shillings and pence, forgetting that these nothings to us were pounds to the poor. Amongst other instances he referred to one mentioned in the Autobiography of Coleridge, who, whilst travelling, observed the postman offering a letter to a poor woman, urging upon her the necessity of taking it in, as it was evidently from her son. The poor woman refused; she could not afford it; but Coleridge charitably paid the shilling for her, and the postman left, when the woman expressed her grateful thanks, but was sorry he had wasted the shilling, for it was only a blank sheet addressed by her son, as a means of informing her he had reached his destination safely. Hundreds of such expedients were then employed, nor could it be wondered at."

If this communication can be of any use for your "Current Notes," it will give great pleasure, Sir, to

Your subscriber,
F. S. DONATO.

BISHOP GIBSON.

London, Feb. 11, 1852.

SIR,—I will be much obliged to any of your correspondents who can inform me to whom Edmund Gibson, the Bishop of London, and a great authority on ecclesiastical laws, was married? and, if possible, the date of such marriage. The biographies of him which have fallen under my notice, have named no domestic circumstances but those of parentage and infancy. I think he died in 1745.

Your obedient servant,
GENEALOGIST.

G. W.'s Correspondent will find it stated in Faulkner's History of Fulham, that "the Bishop died at Bath, September 6, 1748, aged 79, and was buried at Fulham. He married the sister of the wife of Dr. Bettesworth, Dean of the Arches, who died suddenly in her chair, December 28, 1741, and by whom he had several children."

JEWISH SUPERSTITIONS.

The superstitious notions and practices of the Jews in the middle ages, concerning the names of God, were singular. Of these they reckoned 72, from which, by different arrangements in sevens, they produced 720. The principal of these was אגלא, *agla*, which they disposed of in two triangles intersecting each other. This they called the "Shield of David," and pretended that it was a security against wounds, and would extinguish fires, and was able to perform other wonders.

ABRACADABRA.
א ר ב א ד א כ א ר ב א
א ר ב א ד א כ א ר ב
א ר ב א ד א כ א ר
א ר ב א ד א כ א
א ר ב א ד א כ
א ר ב א ד א
א ר ב א ד
א ר ב א
א ר ב
א ר
א

This word, thus written, is a charm for fever or ague, still used by some superstitious persons; it was invented by Basilides, of Alexandria, in the beginning of the 2nd century, to signify the 365 divine processions which he invented, (see Moreri); the value of the letters according to the Greek numbers, make 365 thus:

Α Β Ρ Α Ξ Α Σ *Abraxas*.
1.2.100.1.60.1.200. 365.

Abraxas was a deity adored by the author, and was the root of his charm, as the more mysterious they were the more serviceable they were considered.

The mode of cure described in these verses, *viz.*

Inscribes Chartæ quod dicitur Abracadabra
Sæpius, et subter repetes, sed detrahe Summam,
Et magis atq. magis desint elementa figuris
Singula qua semper capies, et cætera figes
Donec in augustum redigatur Litera Conum.
His lino nexis collum redimere memento.
Talia languentis conducent vincula collo,
Lethalesq. abigent (miranda potentia) morbos.

ARCHÆOLOGY.—Numerous Archæological Societies now exist in different parts of England, of a local character, as in Norfolk, Suffolk, Sussex, Cheshire; and from the Councils of which some printed volumes of Transactions have issued, as appears by occasional references in the public prints. If any of your correspondents have the means of supplying, through your "Current Notes," a list, or short account of the *titles* and *number* of volumes published, it would not only be interesting, but a very useful contribution to the current knowledge of the day, and by the publicity promote their sale, for we folks in the South know but little of what is doing in the North, East, or West.

S. E.

RING OF MARY QUEEN OF SCOTS.

SIR,—Many years ago, when there was a mania for making *Gum* Seals, originating (with me, at least,) from reading of "Lord Oldborough's" seal in "Patronage," by Miss Edgeworth, I had a wax impression given me of Mary Queen of Scots' diamond ring, and its history, which was shewn with it at a sale in London, I think, in 1817. I send you the account and seal, with the copy I made in gum. If it may tend to elucidate what your Correspondent, R. B. ("Current Notes," for February, p. 16) wishes to know, I shall be glad. If it is useless, you can destroy my letter.

M. C. S.

Feb. 28th, 1852.

"1817, June. The original diamond ring of Mary Queen of Scots, upon which are engraved the arms of England, Scotland, and Ireland, quartered, and which was produced in evidence at the trial of the unfortunate Mary, as a proof of her pretensions to the Crown of England, was in possession of the late Mr. Blachford, a Lord of the Admiralty, at the time of his death.[\[A\]](#) The history of this fatal ring is curious: it descended from Mary to her grandson, Charles the First, who gave it, on the scaffold, to Archbishop Juxon, for his son, Charles the Second, who, in his troubles, pawned it in Holland for £300, when it was bought by Governor Yale, and sold at his sale for £320, supposed to the Pretender. Afterwards it came into possession of the Earl of Ilay, Duke of Argyll, and probably from him to the family of Mr. Blachford, at the sale of whose effects it was said to have been purchased for the Prince Regent."

J. W. B. (F. S. A.) writes—"In answer to your correspondent R. B. ("Current Notes," February) I beg to remind him, that the attendants who

shew Holyrood Palace offer for sale to the visitors a *Tassie facsimile* impression seal of "Queen Mary's Signet ring." I myself purchased one last summer, and on looking to the box in which it is enclosed, I find it is stated to be copied from that "in the collection of the late Earl of Buchan." I know not whether the collection alluded to has been dispersed or not. However, if this fact be not already familiar to R. B. it may afford him some clue in his enquiry. I add an impression from the Seal, which exactly tallies with the one engraved in 'Current Notes.'"

RING OF MARY QUEEN OF SCOTS.

SIR,—Having noticed your correspondent R. B.'s communication respecting the above curious relic, I beg to state that I also possess a facsimile of the same engraved upon crystal, an impression of which I enclose for your inspection. I believe the original is in Her Majesty's collection at Windsor Castle.

I am, Sir, respectfully yours,
J. G. P.

15, Park Road, Stockwell.

LITHOGRAPHY.—Your Correspondent, Mr. Cole, is very much mistaken ("Current Notes," for February, p. 12) in supposing that he possesses the very *first* impression in Lithography in England, although it may be from Ackerman's press, and is certainly a curiosity. If Mr. Cole will turn to the second article in the "Foreign Review," No. VII. p. 47, he may find that Lithography was practised in England so early as 1802, and was introduced into France about 1807.

AN ARTIST.

MR. MEADLEY.

March 4, 1852.

SIR,—Can you tell me anything respecting a G. W. Meadley of Bishop Wearmouth, Sunderland? I believe he was author of some two or three works published by Baldwin and Cradock many years since.

Yours truly,
H. K.

SHOVEL BOARD.

New York,
14th January, 1852.

SIR,—It may possibly be amusing to some of your antiquarian friends to know that we have a game in use here, which I never saw or heard of in England, except in Shakspeare's "Merry Wives of Windsor." I allude to Shovel-board, and I can assure you a capital game it is, requiring an eye as quick, and a hand and arm as steady, and much stronger, than billiards, which it somewhat resembles. If you wish it described with the rules of the game, say the word and I'm your man.

SS. R.

Mr. Willis.

G. W. will be glad to receive the information so kindly offered by his Correspondent.

LATIN AND ITALIAN INSCRIPTION.—At Savona, on the Church of the Virgin Mary, occurs the following inscription:—

IN MARE IRATO, IN TORBIDA PROCELLA,
INVOCO TE, NOSTRA BENIGNA STELLA.

Each of the words are both Latin and Italian.

A. A.

MONOGRAM.—The allusion made by your Correspondent C., in your "Current Notes" for February last, p. 11, to my relative Lord Glenelg's signature, reminds me that the letters of the following singular lines, if read backwards, will be found the same as if read in the usual manner.

Signa te, signa, temere me tangis et angis
Româ tibi subito motibus ibit amor.

A. A.

Bombay, July 16th, 1851.

MRS. CRABB.

Mr. Butterworth (7, Fleet Street) requests the attention of the readers of G. W.'s "Current Notes" to the distressing case of the Widow of the late Rev. George Crabb, whose death was recorded in the Literary and Scientific Obituary of last month (p. 16).

This highly respectable lady was, at the age of 80, left perfectly destitute, had it not been for the sum of £60 immediately forwarded for her relief by the Royal Literary Fund. Some friends have since subscribed about the same amount, and Mr. Butterworth's benevolent object is to raise a sum sufficient to purchase an annuity of £50 per annum for Mrs. Crabb—as the "relict of one who has laboured for nearly half a century in the preparation of works of standard usefulness."

TO CORRESPONDENTS.

G. W. fears that he has been taken for a conjuror, and that a serious conspiracy has been organised against him by his esteemed Correspondents (to whose commands he is always happy to respond) and the Post Office. But how is he to get on? He can only in the way of business gratefully acknowledge the favours conferred on him—execute orders—and do his best to reply in the smallest type and space in his power—one column; and with four woodcuts, which would more than occupy it without the illustrative letter-press, being before his eyes.

For these obvious reasons

AUSPICE TEUCRO. (18th March) cannot, according to his request be inserted, as received too late.

S. S. will find in the Piazza upon enquiry a communication and facsimile most politely forwarded by Mr. Cole, in reply to a note headed "AUTOGRAPHIC BIOGRAPHY," in C. N. for Feb. p. 15.

G. S. B. Gainsborough. Thanked: his communication will probably appear next month.

Newspaper paragraphs of the nature referred to (about Shakspeare) seldom require contradiction; but G. W.'s correspondent, as he has kindly mentioned the name of an accomplished Prelate, will perhaps name that of the stupid Newspaper in which the paragraph originally appeared, or the more stupid Newspapers into which such a paragraph could have been copied?

X.'s "extraordinary" communication about "a most extraordinary Story" was duly received. It reminds G. W. of an Old Bailey piece of evidence in the case of a man who stole—not a joke, but a pair of boots that were hanging outside of a shop in Holborn; when followed and apprehended he attempted to excuse himself by saying he had taken them as a joke. The question in consequence by the Counsel was,

"And pray how far did he carry the joke?" "About forty yards"—the reply. Now G. W.'s correspondent admits upon X.'s statement having currently carried the joke from Lincoln's Inn Fields to Covent Garden, and he only wishes that X. would take it back again, without the interest, with some of Rogers's lost Notes.

Mr. Foss, Surgeon, &c., Stockton-on-Tees, 9th March. Thanked. In "Current Notes" for last month no such assertion was made as the discovery of a "City of Pigmies," although it was stated that two dwarfs had been brought from Central America, and were exhibiting in New York. However, for the information of those who are curious upon this subject, G. W.'s correspondent C. F. D. has most kindly forwarded "MORE ABOUT THOSE AZTIC BIPEDS," an extract from the New York Herald, which will be forwarded in the proper quarter.

To G. W.'s AMERICAN CORRESPONDENTS what can he say? beyond sincerely acknowledging his gratitude for the favour of their communications, and at once declaring his belief in the Great Sea Serpent, so voluminous, so overwhelming and really so important has been his Catch from the U. S.

It would literally occupy the space that he will have it in his power to devote to Current Monthly Notes for the current year; and he scarcely knows how to proceed in the task of American Selection.

G. W. however cannot deny himself the pleasure of acknowledging these Catches—respecting Niebuhr and Daniel Webster—"Lord Mahon versus Franklin" is important—but must stand over. So must the Sermon of Dr. Adams of Boston upon the death of Professor Stuart (see "Current Notes" for Feb. p. 16)—"Dickens' American Notes," with Laura Bridgman and Longfellow's Evangeline, appears to be a twaddlish puff. Smarter American verses than Saxe's tribute to Jenny Lind Goldschmidt have come into G. W.'s possession. With Lady Byron's "sayings and doings" at Southampton, on board the American Frigate, G. W. is quite as well informed as any American Newspaper paragraph writer from the "Oriental Hotel" there, can be. The Memory of James Fennimore Cooper is as dear to the Literature of both countries as that of Thomas Moore must be. But alas, their names can

only be recorded in the "Literary and Scientific Obituary" of G. W.'s "Current Notes," almost, it is sad to think, in juxta position. Morris's "Yankee Doodle" G. W. must take in hand next month.

ACTA SANCTORUM received after going to press.

Literary and Scientific Obituary.

BENTLEY, Joseph Clayton. Engraver and Painter. Sydenham. 9th October, 1851. Aged 42.

BLACKWOOD, Robert. Publisher, (Firm of Blackwood and Sons, Edinburgh). 14th February.

DOANE, A. S. Dr. Health Officer, (Author and Translator of Medical Works). New York. 27th January.

KEATE, Rev. John, D.D. Many years Head Master of Eton College. Hartley Westpall, Hants. 5th Feb.

KIRK, Rev. John, D.D. Theology, "The Faith of Catholics," &c. Lichfield. 20th December, 1851.

LAROCHE, Benjamin. Translator of Shakspeare and Byron. Paris, (*lately*). Aged 54.

LEES, Rev. Sir Harcourt, Bart. Political Writer. Blackrock, Dublin. 7th February. Aged 75.

MOORE, Thomas. Poet. Sloperton Cottage, Wiltshire. 25th February. Aged 72.

NEWELL, Rev. Robert Hasell, (Rector of Little Hornead, Herts). Author of three Illustrated works, "On the locality of Goldsmith's Deserted Village," "The Scenery of Wales," and "The Zoology of the English Poets." 31st January. Aged 73.

OXBERRY, William H. Actor. Author of Dramatic Chronology and Dramas. 28th February. Aged 44.

PARANT, S. B. Painter on Porcelain and Ivory. Paris, (*lately*). Aged 54.

THOMPSON, W. C. Natural History. London. 17th February. Aged 47.

FOOTNOTE:

[\[A\]](#) Barrington Pope Blachford, Esq. M.P. was appointed a Lord of the Admiralty on the 23rd August, 1814. He died 14th May, 1816.

Transcriber's Notes:

Obvious punctuation errors repaired.

Page 22, "ב" changed to "ג" so that אַבלָא is now אַגלָא

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK WILLIS'S
CURRENT NOTES, NO. 15, MARCH 1852 ***

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